Piercing the Invisible Shield: Dynamic Morphological Correction of Fetal ECG using Generative AI

Md. Ratul Hasan, Masaba Rahman Suchi

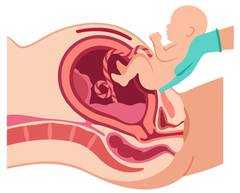
Department of Electrical and Electronic Engineering, Jashore University of Science and Technology

Clinical Problem & Diagnostic Gap

60%

FALSE-POSITIVE C-SECTIONS

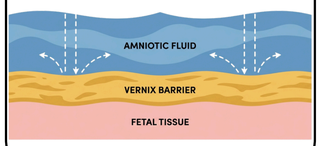
Unnecessary surgical interventions driven by Doppler sensor blindspots



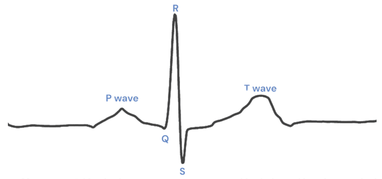
15,000×

RESISTIVE SHIELDING

Vernix (10^{-4} S/m) vs Fluid (1.5 S/m) deflects dorsal cardiac dipoles



Doppler Blindspot: Cardiotocography (CTG) only monitors mechanical heart rate averages, it lacks electrical P-QRS-T morphology to detect acute myocardial ischemia.



Diagnostic Failure: Clinicians cannot reliably distinguish benign fetal sleep states from pathological hypoxia, driving defensive surgical deliveries.
Gestational Peak (Weeks 28–32): Vernix caseosa forms a non-uniform, lipid-dense dielectric coating primarily shielding the fetal spine and dorsal torso.
Pseudo-Hypoxia Artifact: Electric field vectors are deflected away from maternal abdominal leads, suppressing R-peaks and inverting T-waves.

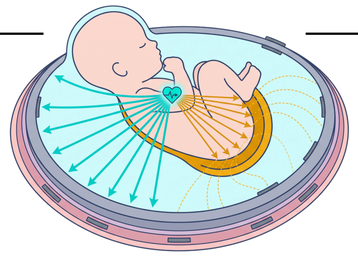


Figure 1: Unshielded anterior propagation vs. dorsal vector deflection across the dielectric vernix layer.

Proposed Solution

Core Hypothesis: Inverting vernix dielectric distortion does not require invasive scalp electrodes; it can be learned computationally via biophysically constrained generative AI.

1 | 3D FEM BIOPHYSICAL DIGITAL TWIN

2 | UNPAIRED 1D-CycleGAN TRANSLATION

3 | ANTI-HALLUCINATION GRADIENT LOSS (L_{morph})

Physiology-Aware Computational Methodology

Phase 1: 3D FEM Biophysical Digital Twin

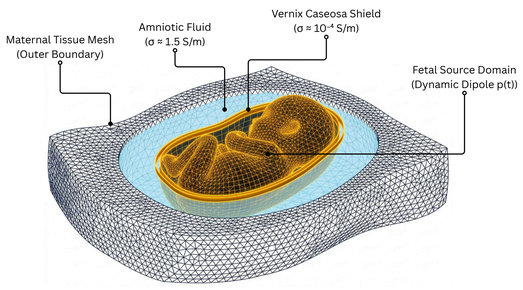


Figure 2: 3D Finite Element Method (FEM) Volume Conductor Architecture.

Governing PDE:

$$\nabla \cdot (\sigma \nabla \Phi) = 0$$

Mesh Discretization: >1.2 × 10^6 tetrahedral elements across segmented anatomical boundaries.

Dielectric Contrast: 15,000 : 1 conductivity ratio $\sigma_{fluid} \approx 1.5$ S/m vs. $\sigma_{vernix} \approx 10^{-4}$ S/m inducing forward vector deflection.

Phase 2: Forward Distortion Vector Engine

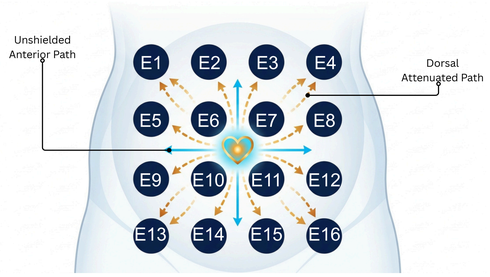


Figure 3: 16-Channel Abdominal Lead-Field Projection Grid.

Governing Transfer Equation:

$$X(t) = H(\sigma) \cdot p(t) + N_{mat}(t) + \eta(t)$$

Lead-Field Matrix H(σ): Computes spatial volume conduction mapping dynamic 3D dipole vectors p(t) to 16 maternal skin coordinates.

Differential Attenuation: Solid cyan paths retain high SNR; dashed amber paths experience up to **70% QRS/T amplitude reduction** due to the dielectric vernix layer.

Noise Superposition: Injects overlapping maternal ECG complexes (N_{mat}) and non-stationary EMG/respiratory baseline drift (η).

Phase 3: 1D-CycleGAN Inverse Reconstruction

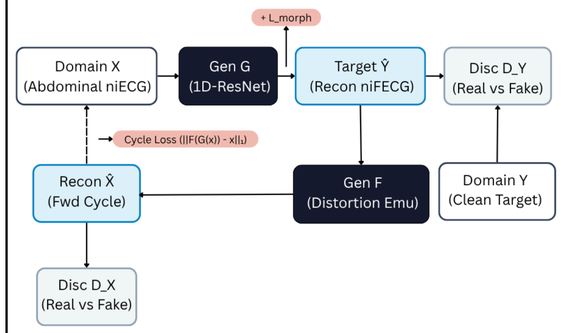


Figure 4: Bidirectional domain translation with morphological gradient loss.

Governing Loss Formula:

$$\mathcal{L}_{total} = \mathcal{L}_{GAN} + \lambda_{cyc}\mathcal{L}_{cyc} + \lambda_{morph} \| \nabla_t G(x) - \nabla_t y \|_1$$

Unpaired Domain Mapping: Reconstructs fetal ECG directly from multi-channel abdominal mixtures without requiring time-synchronized scalp electrode training pairs.

Cycle Consistency (L_cyc): Bidirectional generators (G: X → Y, F: Y → X) enforce structural fidelity, eliminating generative hallucination of phantom cardiac pathologies.

Morphological Gradient Penalty (L_morph): Enforces a first-order temporal derivative constraint $\| \nabla_t G(x) - \nabla_t y \|_1$ to strictly lock QRS slope steepness and preserve true R-peak timing.

Validation Framework & In Silico Benchmarks

Evaluation Protocol (Bulleted Specs):
Cohort Scale: 10,000+ synthetic pairs simulated across gestational weeks 20–40, rotating cardiac axes (cephalic/breech), and variable vernix thickness (0.5-2.0 mm).
Target Clinical Benchmarks: Evaluation on PhysioNet CinC 2013 (Set A/B) targeting $F_1 \geq 95\%$ temporal R-peak detection (±50 ms window), morphological fidelity PRD < 10%, and ΔSNR > 10 dB.

Comparative Feasibility Matrix:

Architecture	Vernix Shield (Wks 28–32)	Hallucination Risk	Training Pair Requirement
FastICA / PCA	Fails (70% signal loss)	None (linear)	Multi-channel independence
Vanilla CycleGAN	Severe phase drift	High (>15 ms jitter)	Unpaired signals
Proposed Framework	Compensated via Mesh	Locked (<2 ms jitter)	Unpaired Synthetic Twins

Clinical Impact & Translational Roadmap

Bypasses Gestational Blindspot: Overcomes the dielectric vernix shield ($\sigma \approx 10^{-4}$ S/m) between gestational weeks 28–32, enabling continuous non-invasive fetal hypoxia detection.

Eliminates Intrapartum Infection Risk: Diagnostic-grade morphological recovery without membrane rupture or invasive scalp electrode (FSE) placement.

Embedded Edge-AI Deployment: Quantized 8-bit 1D-ResNet generator targeting low-power microcontroller hardware for continuous maternal patch monitoring with real-time inference latency under 50 ms.

Translational Validation Roadmap: Phased progression from in silico FEM benchmarking to prospective clinical observational trials, directly correlating reconstructed ST/T waveforms with post-delivery umbilical cord arterial pH and neonatal outcomes.

Selected References

[1] J. G. Stinstra & M. J. Peters, "The influence of fetoabdominal tissues on fetal ECGs and MCGs," Arch. Physiol. Biochem., 2002.
[2] I. Silva et al., "Noninvasive fetal ECG: PhysioNet/CinC Challenge 2013," CinC, 2013.
[3] J.-Y. Zhu et al., "Unpaired Image-to-Image Translation Using Cycle-Consistent Adversarial Networks," IEEE ICCV, 2017.

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